

PHIL 210: Introduction to Philosophy of Mind and Epistemology

Course notes — compiled for midterm review

Chapter 1: Theories of Knowledge

1.1 The Traditional Definition of Knowledge

Since Plato, philosophers have generally analyzed knowledge as justified true belief (JTB). On this view, a person S knows a proposition P if and only if three conditions hold: P is true, S believes that P, and S is justified in believing that P. The truth condition rules out the possibility of knowing something false; you cannot be said to know that the earth is flat, because the proposition itself is false, however sincerely you might believe it. The belief condition requires that the subject actually hold the proposition to be true, rather than merely being aware of it as a possibility. The justification condition is the most philosophically contested of the three, and it exists to rule out knowledge claims that are merely lucky guesses. If you correctly predict a coin flip with no evidence or reasoning behind your guess, your true belief does not amount to knowledge, because it lacks justification.

1.2 The Gettier Problem

In 1963, Edmund Gettier published a short paper that overturned decades of consensus around the JTB analysis. Gettier constructed cases in which a subject holds a justified true belief that nonetheless seems, intuitively, not to count as knowledge. A standard example: Smith has strong evidence that Jones will get a job and that Jones has ten coins in his pocket, leading Smith to justifiably believe 'the person who will get the job has ten coins in his pocket.' Unbeknownst to Smith, Smith himself gets the job, and coincidentally also has ten coins in his pocket. Smith's belief is true and justified, yet it seems wrong to say Smith knew this would happen, since the truth of his belief was disconnected from his justification by pure coincidence. Gettier cases like this motivated philosophers to search for a fourth condition, or an entirely different analysis of knowledge, to rule out justified true beliefs that are true merely by luck.

1.3 Foundationalism versus Coherentism

A separate debate in epistemology concerns the structure of justification itself, sometimes called the regress problem. If belief A is justified by belief B, and belief B is justified by belief C, this chain either continues forever, loops back on itself, or terminates in some belief that requires no further justification. Foundationalists argue the regress terminates in basic or foundational beliefs, typically beliefs about one's own immediate sensory experience, which are self-justifying and do not depend on any further belief for their justification. Coherentists reject the idea of foundational beliefs entirely, arguing instead that justification is a matter of how well a belief fits within an entire

web of mutually supporting beliefs, with no belief being more fundamental than any other. Critics of coherentism worry that an internally consistent but entirely false belief system could still count as justified on this view, a problem sometimes called the isolation objection.

Chapter 2: The Mind-Body Problem

2.1 Cartesian Dualism

Rene Descartes argued that mind and body are two fundamentally different kinds of substance: the body is physical, extended in space, and governed by mechanical laws, while the mind is a non-physical, unextended, thinking substance. Descartes' key argument rests on conceivability: he claimed he could clearly and distinctly conceive of his mind existing without his body, which he took as evidence that mind and body are in fact separable, distinct substances. This view faces the well-known interaction problem: if the mind is entirely non-physical, it becomes deeply unclear how it could causally interact with a physical body, for instance how a mental decision to raise your arm could produce a physical event like the arm actually rising, given that non-physical substances are not supposed to exert physical forces.

2.2 Physicalism and Identity Theory

In reaction to dualism's interaction problem, many twentieth-century philosophers adopted physicalism, the view that mental states simply are physical states of the brain, with nothing non-physical involved at all. Mind-brain identity theory, an early version of physicalism, held that each type of mental state, such as pain, is literally identical to a specific type of brain state, such as the firing of particular neurons. A famous objection to identity theory is the problem of multiple realizability: pain seems to be experienced by creatures with very different neural architectures, such as humans, octopuses, and hypothetically robots or aliens, and it seems implausible that all of these radically different physical states could count as the exact same type of brain state. This objection pushed many philosophers toward functionalism instead.

2.3 Functionalism

Functionalism proposes that mental states are defined not by what they are physically made of, but by the functional role they play, meaning the pattern of causal relations they have to sensory inputs, behavioral outputs, and other mental states. On this view, pain is whatever internal state is typically caused by tissue damage and typically causes wincing, avoidance behavior, and the further mental state of wanting the pain to stop. Because functionalism defines mental states by their causal role rather than their physical substrate, it allows that a state realized in carbon-based neurons and a state realized in silicon-based circuitry could both count as pain, provided the two systems play the same functional role. This makes functionalism compatible in principle with the idea that a sufficiently sophisticated artificial system could have genuine mental states.

2.4 The Hard Problem of Consciousness

Philosopher David Chalmers distinguished between the 'easy problems' of consciousness, which concern explaining cognitive functions like attention, memory, and the reportability of mental states, and the 'hard problem', which concerns explaining why any physical process should be accompanied by subjective experience at all. Even a complete functional and neurological account of how the brain processes the wavelength of red light does not, by itself, seem to explain why

there is something it is like to see red, a felt quality philosophers call qualia. Chalmers argues this explanatory gap suggests consciousness may not be reducible to physical processes in the way physicalists hope, and he uses the thought experiment of 'philosophical zombies', beings physically identical to us in every way but lacking any inner subjective experience, to argue that consciousness involves facts over and above the physical facts.

Chapter 3: Free Will and Determinism

3.1 Hard Determinism

Determinism is the thesis that every event, including every human decision, is the inevitable result of prior causes operating according to the laws of nature, such that given the state of the universe at any earlier time, only one future is physically possible. Hard determinists accept this thesis and further argue that it is incompatible with free will: if your decision to read this sentence was fully caused by prior brain states, which were caused by earlier states, tracing back to events long before you were born, then in what sense could you have done otherwise? Hard determinists conclude that free will, understood as the genuine ability to have chosen differently given identical prior conditions, is an illusion, though many still argue moral responsibility can be preserved in some revised form.

3.2 Libertarian Free Will

Metaphysical libertarians (not to be confused with the political position of the same name) agree that determinism is incompatible with free will, but reject determinism itself, arguing that at least some human choices are not fully determined by prior causes. Some libertarians appeal to indeterminism at the quantum level as a way the causal chain might genuinely break, though critics point out that pure randomness does not obviously give us the kind of control over our actions that free will seems to require either; a choice caused by nothing at all seems no more 'yours' than one fully determined by external causes. Agent-causal libertarians instead propose that free agents themselves are an irreducible source of causation, capable of initiating new causal chains that are not simply the product of prior events.

3.3 Compatibilism

Compatibilists argue that the entire debate rests on a mistaken picture of what free will actually requires. On the compatibilist view, associated with philosophers like Hume and, more recently, Harry Frankfurt, free will does not require the ability to have done otherwise given identical prior causes; it only requires that your action flows from your own desires, reasoning, and character, rather than being coerced by external force or compulsion. Frankfurt's influential account distinguishes first-order desires (wanting to do something) from second-order desires (wanting to have a certain desire). On this view, a drug addict who desires the drug but also desires, at a higher order, not to desire it, is unfree, while a person whose first-order desires align with their own second-order desires is acting freely, even if determinism is true, because freedom is about the source and structure of one's motivations, not about escaping causation itself.

Chapter 4: Personal Identity Over Time

4.1 The Puzzle of Persistence

Personal identity concerns what makes a person at one time the same person as someone existing at another time, given that nearly everything about a person changes over a lifetime: cells are replaced, beliefs shift, memories fade, and personality can transform dramatically. The ancient puzzle of the Ship of Theseus illustrates the underlying difficulty: if a ship has all of its planks gradually replaced over time, is the resulting ship the same ship it was originally? And if the original planks are collected and reassembled elsewhere, which ship, if either, is the 'real' one? Applied to persons, this raises the question of whether identity depends on physical continuity of the body, some form of psychological continuity, or something else entirely.

4.2 Psychological Continuity Theory

John Locke proposed that personal identity consists not in sameness of physical substance but in sameness of consciousness, particularly memory: a person at time two is the same person as one at time one if the later person can remember the experiences of the earlier one, forming an overlapping chain of memory links. Later philosophers, including Derek Parfit, generalized this into psychological continuity theory, which holds that personal identity consists in overlapping chains of psychological connections generally, including memory, but also beliefs, intentions, and personality traits, rather than memory alone. Parfit used the thought experiment of teletransportation, in which a person is scanned, destroyed, and an exact psychological and physical replica is created elsewhere, to argue that what matters in survival may not be strict numerical identity at all, but simply the continuation of enough of the right kind of psychological connections, even if, strictly speaking, a new physical entity is created.

4.3 The No-Self View

A more radical position, associated with Buddhist philosophy and echoed by Parfit himself in his more skeptical moments, holds that there is no deep further fact about personal identity at all, only a series of causally connected mental and physical events that we conventionally group together and label with a single name. On this 'no-self' or reductionist view, questions like 'will I still exist after this procedure' may simply lack a determinate yes-or-no answer in edge cases like teletransportation or gradual brain replacement, not because we lack information, but because personal identity was never the kind of sharp, all-or-nothing fact our intuitions assume it to be. Parfit argued that fully accepting this view should change how much we fear death and how strongly we should be prudentially concerned with our own distant future, since the connection between our present self and our future self is a matter of degree rather than an unbreakable metaphysical fact.